president we have to *always give a chair.* If we give that chair, the booth president will move a little forward. He gets honoured and comes forward to work. So, his graph rose in the party.'[31]

The result was greater local reach and a more empowered local cadre. If a booth president complains about an MLA or an MP, said a local corporator, 'he is now taken seriously'. If he complains about 'us', he summed up, '*hamaare kaan khare ho jaate hain* [our ears perk up]. That is the big change.'[32]

The new BJP's party structure is built upwards from the booth. While there are variations between BJP state units, the basic principle of strengthening the voting-booth ranks is common everywhere. In Karnataka, in February 2020, the party had counted over 8,00,000 lakh active party workers. Sitting in BJP's Bengaluru office in Malleshwaram, N. Ravi Kumar, the party's state general secretary, explained the break-up of this number and how the organisational tree branches upwards. The state has '58,000 booths, so we have 58,000 booth presidents. Then we have two secretaries per booth, so that means 116,000 booth secretaries. Then we have 58,000 booth pramukhs. Each booth has a thirteen-member committee, so that amounts to 13* 58,000 people, i.e. 754,000 members. Then there are thirty-seven districts and district committee members are 160. We have 300 mandals in the state and sixty members in each mandal—like karyakari member, executive member, mandal president, vice president, general secretary and so on.'[33]

Nationally, India has 10,35,000 voting booths. The BJP claims that it had set up booth-level committees in 83 per cent of these (8,63,000) between 2014 and 2019. The party also identified 1,64,000 clusters of booths (each cluster acting as a nodal point for five–seven booths each). The BJP termed these clusters 'Shakti Kendras', or Power Centres. It had set up operations in 92 per cent of these (1,52,000) within the 2014–2019 period.[34]

The BJP's 2019 election campaign was built on the cascading layers of this organisational structure. While popular attention focused on the big leaders and the Modi–Gandhi contest, the BJP began its poll campaign first with nationwide booth sammelans (meetings). The membership-expansion drive after the 2014